hopes rising again. They began collecting food, arms and ammunition, and, encouraged by their key ally Aminullah Khan Logari, began negotiating with the Tajiks of Kohistan in a bid to recruit more troops to their cause. As so often in the past, Kabul fractured into rival quarters of Barakzai and Sadozai influence, with Nawab Zaman Khan's Barakzai troops desperately defending their compounds against Aminullah and his Sadozai allies. 'Ameenoollah's power is daily increasing,' reported Mohan Lal Kashmiri in a despatch to Jalalabad on 10 April. 'He has command of the Treasury of the Shah and Futteh Jung, and is collecting the men of his own tribe, the Loghurrees.'[29]

Lady Sale, characteristically, took a more forthright view of events. 'Parties run high at Kabul,' she wrote in her diary. 'Nawab Zaman Khan says he will be king, Akbar ditto, Jubbar Khan the same, and Ameenoollah has a similar fancy, as also Mahommed Shah Khan, and Futteh Jung, the Shahzada.' She added:

> Troops go out daily to fight . . . Now is the time to strike the blow, but I much dread dilly-dallying just because a handful of us are in Akbar's power. What are our lives when compared to the honour of our country? Not that I am at all inclined to have my throat cut: on the contrary, I hope that I shall live to see the British flag once more triumphant in Affghanistan; and then I shall have no objection to the Ameer Dost Mahomed Khan being reinstated: only let us first show them that we can conquer them, humble their treacherous chiefs to the dust and revenge the foul murder of our troops; but let us not dishonour the British name by sneaking out of the country like whipped pariah dogs . . .
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> Let our Governors-General and Commanders in Chief look to that; whilst I knit socks for my grandchildren: but I have been a soldier's wife too long to sit down tamely whilst our honour is tarnished . . . Were I in power I would make the Chiefs remember it. A woman's vengeance is said to be fearful but nothing can satisfy mine against Akbar, Sultan Jan and Mohammad Shah Khan.[30]

The stalemate and uncertainty was broken on 9 May, when Akbar Khan arrived back in Kabul. With his usual vigour and decisiveness, he immediately laid siege to the Sadozais in their fortress, digging a series of massive mines under the most vulnerable towers. Using the same tactics that had served him so well while gathering supporters in Jalalabad, he again represented himself as the champion of Islam, and depicted the Sadozais as quisling friends of the Kafirs. He wrote to the chiefs that 'it was an object of paramount importance that in the contest with the race of misguided infidels the whole of the members of the true faith should be united together, therefore did the whole of the devoted followers of the true